dishes and food from a kosher restaurant in London. The Sabbath dinner, in the presence of the king and his cousin, Jordanian prime minister Zaid Ibn Shaker, was conducted according to the rules of *halacha*, and Sabbath songs were sung. On Saturday night, the *havdalah* ceremony was held, marking the end of the Sabbath and the beginning of the new week. Over the course of the two days, several meetings were held in various constellations, in addition to three-way talks between the prime minister, the king, and Efraim, who documented the meeting (he relied on the principle of *pikuach nefesh*, whereby the preservation of human life overrides religious considerations, to justify his writing on the Sabbath). It was only the second meeting between the prime minister and the king, and from the very first moment there was a "click" between them. Those close to them used to joke that this chemistry was due to the two of them being able to talk to each other at eye level.

Moving on from the backdrop of the meeting to its content: at the heart of the talks between the king and the prime minister was the tangible tension on the eve of the outbreak of war between President Bush's coalition and Iraq. Even then, the prime minister was under heavy pressure from President Bush not to intervene in the anticipated war, for fear that Israeli involvement would endanger the coalition the US had built with most of the Arab states in the Middle East. The king's circumstances were no less difficult, for he had chosen to support Saddam Hussein in the impending war. According to what was later published in the press, the king took the time to explain to the prime minister the background and reasons for his decision. The prime minister, it was reported, asked the king to agree that in the unlikely case that it was necessary, the Israeli air force could cross Jordanian airspace on its way to attack targets in Iraq. The king refused, explaining to Shamir that for him it would be suicide—the Arab world would see him as a traitor and condemn him to death. After a lengthy discussion, the king pledged that he would not allow the Iraqi air force to fly over Jordan and would prevent Iraqi ground forces from entering the kingdom. The king requested and received the prime minister's word that Israel would not mobilize reserve forces for deployment on the Jordanian front and would not infringe on Jordanian sovereignty in its airspace.

About a week after Prime Minister Shamir's return to Israel, the First Gulf War broke out. It was January 16, 1991. During this period, the cabinet held its meetings at the base of the IDF general staff, in the conference